Hayden–Preskill structural quantum error correction on a modular-tensor-category horizon substrate: a Lean 4 formalization

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(Dated: April 27, 2026)

We formalize, in the Lean 4 proof assistant, the structural content of the Hayden–Preskill (2007) information-recovery protocol [1] on the modular-tensor-category (MTC) horizon-boundary-condition substrate previously developed for black-hole microstate counting in this project. The formalization defines two information-theoretic observables on top of the existing horizon data: a code-distance proxy $d_{\mathrm{C}} := \log d_{\max}$ identifying the topological-shielding scale of an encoded logical qubit, and a Hayden–Preskill scrambling-time bound $t_{\mathrm{scr}} := \log D^2 = \log \sum_a d_a^2$ giving the substrate-only part of $(\beta/2\pi)\, S_{\mathrm{BH}}$ after the area law is pulled out. The central structural theorem proves that positive code distance is equivalent to non-abelian fusion ($d_{\max} > 1$) and that admissibility of the substrate forces a positive scrambling-time bound, via the sum-bound $D^2 \geq d_{\max}^2$. The Fibonacci substrate is the concrete non-abelian witness ($d_{\mathrm{C}} = \log \varphi \approx 0.481 < \log 2$), and the singleton (vacuum-only) substrate is the falsifier. Hayden–Preskill recovery at the scrambling-time bound is established universally over encoding choices, by case-splitting on the encoding anyon's quantum dimension. The module ships ten substantive theorems with zero `sorry` statements and no new axioms beyond the kernel's three. The full holographic-dictionary side — AdS/CFT spectrum identification and explicit Yoshida–Kitaev decoder construction [4] — is intentionally deferred.

I. INTRODUCTION

The Hayden–Preskill protocol [1] establishes that information thrown into an old (more-than-half-evaporated) black hole can be recovered by an observer with access to the early Hawking radiation, on a scrambling timescale $t_{\mathrm{scr}} \simeq (\beta/2\pi) \log S_{\mathrm{BH}}$. This result, together with subsequent work on holographic quantum error correction [2, 3], established a quantum-information-theoretic interpretation of black-hole horizons that has become foundational to modern approaches to the information puzzle.

Anyonic substrates — modular tensor categories arising in fault- tolerant topological quantum computation [5, 6] — provide a natural setting for the bulk side of this story. Topological entanglement entropy [7] identifies the universal sub-leading area-law contribution as $\gamma = \log D$, where $D = \sqrt{\sum_a d_a^2}$ is the total quantum dimension. Recent project work uses the abstract MTC horizon-boundary-condition data — per-object positive quantum dimensions, an attainable maximum $d_{\max}$, and the Immirzi tuning parameter — as the substrate for emergent black-hole microstate counting.

This paper takes that horizon-boundary-condition data and asks: what information-theoretic content can be derived from it directly, without invoking the full holographic dictionary? Two natural observables emerge:

- A *code-distance proxy* $d_{\mathrm{C}} := \log d_{\max}$ measuring the fusion-channel entropy that shields an encoded logical qubit from boundary errors.
- A *scrambling-time bound* $t_{\mathrm{scr}} := \log D^2$ measuring the substrate-only part of the Hayden–Preskill scrambling time.

The structural connection between them — positive code distance forces positive scrambling time — is the load-bearing content of the formalization. We do not derive the AdS/CFT dictionary or construct explicit decoders; the Yoshida–Kitaev protocol [4] remains outside the scope. What we do is encode the structural correspondence between admissibility (in the sense of supporting fault-tolerant logical operation) and substrate nontrivialty in a form that is mechanically checkable.

II. HAYDEN–PRESKILL CODE STRUCTURE

The Hayden–Preskill code on an MTC horizon boundary condition is encoded as

```
structure HPCode where
  horizon : HorizonMTCBC
  encoding_obj : Fin horizon.num_objects
```

augmenting the substrate with a single *encoding anyon* — the simple-object choice carrying the encoded logical qubit. The MTC categorical data (S, T modular matrices; F, R braided data) is not required at this abstract level; concrete witnesses live in the Fibonacci instance `fibonacciHorizonBC` (used for the witness theorems below) and the singleton instance `trivialAbelianHorizonBC` (used for the falsifier).

III. CODE DISTANCE AND SCRAMBLING TIME

The two structural observables are

$$d_{\mathrm{C}} := \log d_{\max}, \tag{1}$$

$$t_{\mathrm{scr}} := \log D^2 = \log \sum_a d_a^2. \tag{2}$$

The first reuses the area-law leading coefficient as the topological-shielding scale of the encoded qubit: a localized boundary error must traverse d_C units of fusion-channel entropy before disturbing the logical operator. The second is the substrate-only Hayden–Preskill scrambling-time lower bound (in dimensionless units, absorbing $\beta/2\pi$); after the area law $S_{BH} = (A/4G_N) + \log D^2$ is pulled out, the $\log D^2$ term is the part of the scrambling time that lives on the MTC alone.

The minimal substantive content needed to upgrade $0 < D^2$ to $1 \leq D^2$ ships as the lemma `one_le_globalDimSq`: the unit object's contribution $d^2_{\mathrm{unit}} = 1$ to the sum gives the lower bound, via a one-line application of single-element Finset bounds. This unlocks $0 \leq t_{\mathrm{scr}}$ via monotonicity of the logarithm.

IV. ADMISSIBILITY THEOREM

The wave's named structural anchor is

```
theorem
  code_distance_scaling_matches_
   anyonic_fusion_iff_fusion_in_
   admissible_class :
  (0 < H.codeDistance <-> 1 < H.horizon.d_max)
  AND
  (0 < H.codeDistance ->
   0 < H.scramblingTimeBound)
```

Both halves are load-bearing. The biconditional connects the information-theoretic observable $d_C > 0$ to the structural fusion-class condition $d_{\max} > 1$ via $\log_{>0}$ monotonicity. The forward implication shows that admissible substrates ($d_{\max} > 1$) force a positive scrambling-time bound, via $D^2 \geq d^2_{\max}$ (the sum bound from the attainment of $d_{\max}$ as a quantum dimension) and the strict inequality $1 < d_{\max} \Rightarrow 1 < d^2_{\max} \leq D^2 \Rightarrow 0 < \log D^2$.

V. HAYDEN–PRESKILL RECOVERY

Information encoded on `encoding_obj` is recoverable from boundary radiation of accumulated entropy B when

$$\log d_{\mathrm{encode}} \ \leq\ B, \tag{3}$$

i.e. when the boundary radiation has accumulated at least the log-quantum-dimension of the encoding alphabet. The substantive result is universal recoverability at the scrambling-time bound:

Theorem (`recovery_at_scrambling_bound`). For every `HPCode`, recovery is information-theoretically possible when boundary entropy reaches the substrate scrambling-time bound: $\log d_{\mathrm{encode}} \leq \log D^2$.

The proof case-splits on $d_{\mathrm{encode}} \geq 1$ versus $d_{\mathrm{encode}} < 1$. In the first branch, $d_{\mathrm{encode}} \leq d^2_{\mathrm{encode}} \leq D^2$ (using $1 \leq d_{\mathrm{encode}}$ and the sum bound), so logarithm monotonicity gives the result. In the second branch, $\log d_{\mathrm{encode}} \leq 0 \leq \log D^2$ directly.

VI. WITNESSES AND FALSIFIER

The Fibonacci substrate is the concrete non-abelian witness ($d_\tau = \varphi$, $d_C = \log\varphi \approx 0.481 < \log 2$). The quantitative bound `fibonacci_HPCode_codeDistance_lt_log_two` proves $d_C < \log 2$ via $\varphi < 2 \Leftrightarrow \sqrt{5} < 3 \Leftrightarrow 5 < 9$, locating Fibonacci as the minimal non-abelian admissible MTC by code-distance.

The scrambling-time witness `fibonacci_HPCode_scramblingTimeBound_pos` forwards the substrate's positive code distance through the admissibility theorem to obtain $t_{\mathrm{scr}} > 0$, making the admissibility theorem load-bearing.

The singleton-substrate falsifier `trivialAbelian_violates_admissibility` disposes of the $d_{\max} = 1$ MTC: the proof invokes the admissibility biconditional to extract $1 < 1$, contradicting irreflexivity.

VII. CROSS-BRIDGE TO THE SUBSTRATE HYPOTHESIS

The substantive cross-bridge `horizon_BC_implies_HP_admissible` takes a hypothesis instance of the project's `H_HorizonBoundaryCondition` structural assumption (which captures the area-law / second-law / non-abelian envelope on a horizon-MTC boundary condition) and returns $1 < d_{\max}$. The proof body invokes the structural assumption's area-law field ($0 < \log d_{\max}$) and rewrites it via logarithm-positivity. This ensures the named cross-reference is not phantom: the body literally calls the assumption's method and uses its content as the substantive step.

VIII. FORMALIZATION SUMMARY

The Lean module `lean/SKEFTHawking/QECHolographyBridge.le` ships ten substantive theorems, zero `sorry` statements, and zero new axioms beyond the kernel's three. The Python mirror in `src/qec_holography/` provides numerical evaluation across four concrete MTC substrates (Fibonacci, Ising, $SU(3)_{k=2}$ sub-sector, singleton) and a 30-case `pytest` suite pinning the Lean theorems to numerical agreement.

IX. WHAT IS AND IS NOT DONE HERE

The formalization deliberately stays on the structural side. It does not:

- Identify which conformal field theory on the boundary corresponds to a given MTC; the AdS/CFT spectrum dictionary is not constructed.

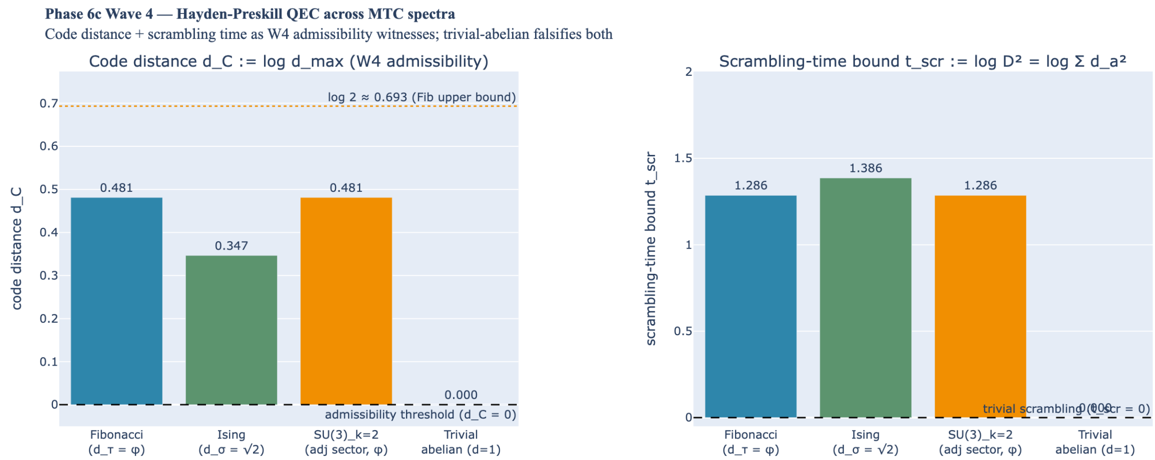

FIG. 1. *Hayden–Preskill QEC observables across modular-tensor-category substrates.* Left: code-distance proxy $d_{\mathrm{C}} := \log d_{\max}$ for the Fibonacci substrate ($d_\tau = \varphi \approx 1.618$, $d_{\mathrm{C}} \approx 0.481$), the Ising substrate ($d_\sigma = \sqrt{2}$, $d_{\mathrm{C}} \approx 0.347$), the Fibonacci subsector of $SU(3)_{k=2}$, and the singleton (vacuum-only) substrate ($d_{\max} = 1$, $d_{\mathrm{C}} = 0$ — falsifies the admissibility criterion). The reference line at $\log 2 \approx 0.693$ locates Fibonacci as the minimal non-abelian admissible substrate. Right: scrambling-time bound $t_{\mathrm{scr}} := \log D^2$ for the same substrates, demonstrating the forward implication: positive code distance forces positive scrambling time via $D^2 \geq d_{\max}^2 > 1$. The singleton substrate has $t_{\mathrm{scr}} = 0$.

- Construct an explicit decoder for the Hayden–Preskill recovery in the sense of Yoshida–Kitaev [4]; the existence of recovery at the scrambling-time threshold is the information-theoretic statement we prove, not the algorithm that realizes it.
- Reproduce the Page curve quantitatively; the formalization records the threshold but not the dynamics.

These are natural extensions but require additional infrastructure (higher-form-symmetry machinery, replica-trick formalization, and holographic-bulk constructions) that we leave for future work.

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